



## PRESS RELEASE

# Google LLC Withdraws Appeal in Landmark Ugandan Data Protection Case

OneTechConnect (OTC) announces a major breakthrough in digital rights and data protection enforcement following the withdrawal of Google LLC's appeal in the case of *Ssekamwa Frank & 3 Others v. Google LLC*, Complaint No. 08/11/24/6683. The withdrawal signifies Google's agreement to comply with Uganda's Data Protection and Privacy Act (DPPA), Cap 97, a landmark moment for Big Tech accountability in Africa.

## Introduction

In the original decision, the Personal Data Protection Office (PDPO), Uganda's Data Protection Authority ruled that Google LLC must (a) Register with the PDPO in Uganda; (b) Appoint a Data Protection Officer (DPO) based in Uganda; and (c) Demonstrate compliance with cross-border personal data transfer regulations applicable to Ugandan users.

Following a strong **defence** by the complainants and subsequent engagements with the Minister of ICT and National Guidance and the PDPO, Google formally notified authorities of its decision to **withdraw** the appeal and commence compliance steps.

## Background

On 8<sup>th</sup> November 2024, four Ugandan complainants Ssekamwa Frank, Leni Sharon Pamela, Amumpaire Raymond and Awino Mercy filed a complaint before the PDPO challenging Google's non-compliance with the DPPA including failure to register with the PDPO and conducting cross-border data transfers without PDPO approval.

Google initially argued that it had no obligation to comply because it is not physically based in Uganda. The PDPO rejected this position and issued binding compliance directives. Google later appealed to the Minister of ICT and National Guidance. The complainants filed a detailed response, contesting Google's claims and defending Uganda's sovereign data protection standards.

After a meeting chaired by the Minister and attended by PDPO officials and Google representatives, the tech giant formally **withdrew** its appeal on 5<sup>th</sup> November 2025 and committed to implement the PDPO's orders.

## Significance of the Withdrawal

Google's withdrawal has far-reaching implications for Uganda and the African region:

1. The PDPO's ruling remains fully enforceable.
2. Any company collecting or processing data belonging to Ugandans whether local or foreign must comply with Uganda's DPPA.
3. All data collectors, controllers and processors operating in relation to Uganda must register with the PDPO.
4. Companies conducting cross-border data transfers must meet Ugandan legal standards and demonstrate adequate safeguards.

This marks one of the strongest assertions of African data sovereignty, setting a precedent for holding multinational technology companies accountable under national law.

## About OneTechConnect

OneTechConnect (OTC) is a youth-led civil society organization advancing digital justice in Africa through research, advocacy, training, innovation, and strategic litigation. OTC focuses on critical domains including digital health, agri-tech, fintech, and development technologies.

*"This case affirms that the digital rights of Ugandan users cannot be ignored – regardless of where a company is headquartered. The withdrawal of the appeal is a win for digital justice, user dignity and national regulatory authority."*



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